

Aesthetic movement

Inspired predominantly by Pre-Raphaelitism, an art movement developed in France and Britain in the 1860s that focused almost entirely on beauty. It began in reaction to what was viewed as the ugliness of the industrial age, and manifested in fine art and design simultaneously. Artists involved (Aesthetes), included James McNeill Whistler (1834–1903), Albert Moore (1841–93), Leighton and Burne-Jones. They used soft colours in complex juxtapositions, subtle blending techniques and emphasized beauty and decoration. The phrase 'art for art's sake', identifying beauty as the most important element in fine art and design, was popularized by French poet and critic Théophile Gautier (1811–72) and later reflected in the writings of Oscar Wilde (1854–1900) and the illustrations of Aubrey Beardsley (1872–98).

With his designs inspired by Japanese prints, harmonious tones and colours, Whistler exemplified the movement, but also shared affinities with the French Symbolists. Burne-Jones's ethereal, graceful paintings, helped inspire later Art Nouveau.



Whistler, *Arrangement in Grey and Black No. 1 (Whistler's Mother)*, 1871